

Including residents in the rebranding of tourist destinations to achieve sustainable development goals

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Abstract

Purpose – This paper aims to indicate the importance of including residents in the rebranding of a destination.

Design/methodology/approach – This article is based on a literature review.

Findings – The World Tourism Organization recently adapted the United Nations' 17 Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) to show their relevance to tourism. The quality of life of the residents was a common theme of these goals. Through a review of literature, the paper identified the negative and positive effects of tourism on the residents' quality of life. This was done to show how destination management organizations (DMOs) could design and manage their tourism activities to avoid the negative effects on residents and maximize the positive benefits.

Originality/value – As tourist destinations strive to meet sustainability goals, we argue that many will have to be rebranded. The paper shows how through the rebranding process the destination can create brand identity elements that communicate as well as guide their sustainability efforts. Also, just as corporations need to include and have employees that believe and support the company's brand identity elements, DMOs must include residents in the branding process and gain their support of the destination's brand identity elements. As practical implications for DMOs, the paper shows the importance of developing tourism policies that will enhance the life of residents, demonstrating how this can be accomplished through a rebranding process. As research implications, there is a call for researchers to measure the results of destination's rebranding efforts including the satisfaction of residents as a construct. To accomplish this there is also a need to develop a reliable and valid scale of resident satisfaction with tourism policies.

Keywords Sustainable tourism, Destination branding, Residents, Social impact, Sustainable development goals, Brand identity, Co-creation, Rebranding

Paper type Conceptual paper

Introduction

The United Nations World Tourism Organization (UNWTO) has developed insight into how each of the United Nations' 17 Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) relates to tourism (UNWTO, 2018). For many DMOs, aligning with these SDGs requires them to develop a new brand for their destination. The starting point for this rebranding is to create a new vision – one that goes beyond considering tourism to be a major economic contributor to an area and that realigns with not only UNWTO SDGs, ensuring it creates value for tourists, but also businesses and residents of the tourist destination. This last group is often excluded in the development of a destination's brand. However, just as corporate brands need to be relevant to employees (Aaker, 2014), destination brands must be relevant to residents. The extant literature supports the positive role residents can play in supporting tourism when they identify with the destination's tourism policy and the negative effect they can have when they do not. A number of UNWTO's SDGs focus on residents, further supporting the need to involve residents in the tourism branding effort. Related to this is the importance of education. Business and management education enables residents to run successful



businesses, as well as hold management and supervisory positions in hospitality and tourism companies. Moreover, providing education so that residents can succeed in entry-level positions is crucial. One of the components of education should be inclusivity so all residents have equal access to opportunities created by tourism. According to the [UNTWO \(2018\)](#), tourism should achieve these goals while creating a sustainable environment that features clean water and air, improves infrastructure and reduces the emission of greenhouse gases. This paper uses extant literature to demonstrate that creating a tourism vision that supports residents also creates value for tourists. Finally, the interaction between tourists and residents can lead to a cross-cultural understanding of people across the globe.

This article aims to indicate the importance of including residents in the rebranding of a destination. The paper first discusses the negative effects of tourism on locals and the consequences of these negative effects. Next, it explores the benefits tourism can bring to residents when it is properly managed. Finally, the paper discusses the integration of residents into the tourism branding process.

Literature review

Negative effects of tourism on residents

The negative effects of tourism have been well documented ([Yasothersrikul and Bowen, 2015](#)). These include social, cultural, environmental and economic effects. The social-cultural ones include what has been called the demonstration effect ([Ajagunna and Crick, 2014](#); [Edelmann, 1975](#)). This occurs when residents try to emulate tourists by adopting their behavior, and in the process, they let go of their culture in favor of the tourists'. This acculturation is more rapid with younger residents ([Edelmann, 1975](#)) and can cause family conflict, as the young give up cultural traditions and values still held by the older generations. Due to their economic situation, residents may try but are unable to emulate tourists' consumption of material goods, including their fashion styles. When this occurs, residents become aware of their limited ability to consume products, creating both frustration toward and envy of the tourists. This often leads to an ill feeling toward tourists ([Ajagunna and Crick, 2014](#); [Edelmann, 1975](#)). [Biagi and Detotto \(2014\)](#) highlight this aggression toward tourists through the vignette of a local who snatches a purse from a woman in an Italian tourist area. When the woman screams at him in perfect Italian, the thief asks her where she is from. On learning she is also a local, he returns her purse and apologizes. This story highlights that the focus of many petty crimes by residents is on tourists. When crime against tourists becomes prevalent, one solution to protect tourists is preventing contact with locals. They are placed behind gated walls in all-inclusive resorts, which are often run by large multinational companies ([Ajagunna and Crick, 2014](#)). Once this happens, opportunities for local entrepreneurs to benefit from the tourist trade diminish. Ironically, many travelers are now seeking authentic local experiences, which are difficult to obtain from an all-inclusive resort. [Altindag \(2014\)](#) claims that as violent crime rises by 10% at a destination, tourism dollars decline by \$US140 million.

It is also ironic that tourism can be a major source of pollution, as tourists are attracted to a destination with a clean environment ([Kort et al., 2002](#)). The environmental effects of tourism can be widespread if tourism developments are not properly planned. When a tourist project damages the environment, it affects not only the residents but also the number of tourists visiting the destination ([Kort et al., 2002](#)). [Klein \(2011\)](#) cites several waste streams from cruise ships that have the potential to pollute the environment. These include bilgewater, human waste, solid waste and emissions from engines. [Klein \(2011\)](#) also adds another type of pollution – people pollution, when multiple cruise ships arrive and thousands of passengers disembark at destinations, often outnumbering residents. This type of human congestion completely changes the social environment of a town. Ski resorts are known for their use of

electricity and for deforestation (Wang *et al.*, 2020). This allows for skiers to have great experiences on the slopes but at the expense of the environment. Sajjad *et al.* (2014) report the results of a study that found air pollution related to air conditioning in tourist accommodations and transportation used by tourists. The damage to environmental resources caused by a lack of proper tourism planning and regulations can be negative to locals, who depend on these resources to subsist.

The economic benefits of tourism are not always evenly dispersed across the population. Sometimes, the economic benefits of tourism can be limited to the wealthy or multinational organizations. When this occurs, resentment from the locals can follow. For example, Airbnb has created an opportunity for owners of living units in tourist destinations to increase the value of their property by renting to tourists on a nightly or weekly basis (Nieuwland and Van Melik, 2020). This has led to the acquisition of property by new owners attracted to the profits that can be made from renting to tourists. This results in upward pressure on rent for the remaining units – forcing some locals to relocate (sometimes to a less desirable part of the city), as they can no longer afford the rent. Better jobs in the tourism economy are usually given to nonresidents, and the lack of education inhibits residents' ability to fully participate in the financial opportunities created by tourism. For example, if governments do not provide the education needed for residents to advance into management positions and multinational firms running large resorts do not offer formal training, many locals will end up in lower-paid positions (Baum *et al.*, 2016). In many destinations, there is a need to train locals so they can fully participate in the economic benefits provided by tourism.

Barriers to entry are sometimes created for small businesses supporting tourism. For example, cruise lines presell tours on ships, limiting the ability of local entrepreneurs to participate in the tourist economy. In Alaska, indigenous tourist guides indicated to one of the authors that they were harassed by the large tour operators. Entrepreneurs can often face negative forces. Local shop owners in areas frequented by tourists have seen rents increase, forcing them to relocate or close. The average income in Belize is low, with a typical annual wage of \$USD7,000 (Average Salary Survey, 2021). The cruise lines have developed a village behind gates as a safe and clean environment for cruise passengers. This protects tourists from crimes. As Peterson (2021) states, "It's no secret that Belize City is a cesspool of crime." Although the village protects tourists, it prevents many locals from benefiting from tourism. As mentioned earlier, this leads to crimes against tourists by residents. When residents' lives have not been improved by or may have even deteriorated because of tourism, they cannot be expected to support it (Ajagunna and Crick, 2014).

Benefits of tourism to residents

Despite its possible negative impact, it is important to recognize that tourism has the potential to bring several economic, social and environmental benefits to residents of host communities if managed with a sustainable approach. For instance, it has been argued that tourism development fosters the implementation of better public infrastructure, facilities and services at the destination (Dyer *et al.*, 2007; Tovar and Lockwood, 2008), improving the overall well-being or quality of life of residents (Andereck and Nyaupane, 2011; Kim *et al.*, 2013; Uysal *et al.*, 2016). Furthermore, given that security increases at destinations once they become touristic, residents benefit from more everyday security measures, which keep visitors coming, and even better crisis response plans (Prashyanusorn *et al.*, 2010; Scott and Laws, 2006). Regarding the cultural aspects, during the interactions between visitors and residents, cultural exchanges wherein different lifestyles are appreciated take place. Consequently, good foreign customs may be adopted (Barbieri *et al.*, 2020). Some authors have even suggested that this greater understanding generates goodwill between nations and may become a catalyst for building peace (Archer *et al.*, 2005; Becken and Carmignani, 2016; Cho,

2007). In addition, when residents perceive the appreciation of their cultural traditions, they make efforts to preserve them (Archer *et al.*, 2005; Lusetyowati, 2015) and even reauthenticate some, allowing them to revitalize their acceptance among the younger generation (Sotomayor *et al.*, 2019).

Tourism development can also make residents feel prouder of the place they live in (Gursoy *et al.*, 2019b), which can lead to lower migration indexes and even encourage locals who once migrated to return, as they now recognize professional opportunities in their hometowns (Barbieri *et al.*, 2020; Stronza and Gordillo, 2008). This increasing sense of pride can also be reflected in greater civic involvement in demanding actions from the government to preserve their tangible and intangible resources as well as to get actively involved in the decision-making processes regarding tourism planning, tourism development and the operation of attractions in their areas (Haley *et al.*, 2005). As suggested by Boley *et al.* (2017), this relates to the different kinds of empowerment (i.e. overarching empowerment, political empowerment, economic empowerment, social empowerment, psychological empowerment and environmental empowerment) that residents may experience due to tourism development. Interestingly, it has been argued that groups that have been traditionally marginalized within their cultures – such as women in rural areas – may benefit the most from this empowerment (Boley *et al.*, 2017; Gentry, 2007; Scheyvens, 2000; Tucker and Boonabaana, 2012). This is because by taking advantage of job opportunities outside of their households, they can generate additional income for their families, which has many positive repercussions for them (Gil Arroyo *et al.*, 2019). It is worth mentioning that, according to Saayman and Giampiccoli (2016), a tourism development model that pursues this empowerment and shift of control, ownership and management in favor of the vulnerable population living in touristic places and/or representing an attraction themselves is referred to as community-based tourism. The authors argue that unlike other models, such as pro-poor tourism, community-based tourism does not propose eliminating poverty with “charity” or by “inserting” the poor into mainstream tourism, but it aims for a more just and equitable distribution of power/control, resources, knowledge, capacities and benefits.

Research on residents’ attitudes toward tourism has established that residents exhibit greater support for the tourism sector when they perceive benefits for themselves, their families and their communities (McGehee and Andereck, 2004; Neuts *et al.*, 2021). Thus, to minimize the negative impact of tourism, its development should incorporate a sustainable approach, as recommended in the United Nations’ strategy to realize SDGs (Milán-García *et al.*, 2019).

Even though achieving and maintaining sustainable growth in tourist destinations has been recognized as one of the biggest challenges for DMOs in recent years (Choi and Sirakaya, 2005), many authors have suggested that the crisis originated by the COVID-19 pandemic should be seen as a break or a pause that DMOs, as a sector, should take advantage of to pursue a real transformation with an actionable focus on equity (Ateljevic, 2020; Benjamin *et al.*, 2020; Haywood, 2020).

Need for a new brand vision

The metrics for measuring the success of a DMO often relate to the economic contribution of tourists to the local economy, including average spending per visitor, breaking it down into lodging, transportation, food and beverage and entertainment. Other metrics include the number of visitors by segment, return visitors and visitor satisfaction. Resident satisfaction with tourism is hardly ever included in these metrics. Yet, as the literature demonstrates, tourism will suffer in the long term if residents cannot appreciate its benefits. UNWTO’s (2018) SDGs include goals to ensure that tourism improves the life of residents, such as making sure tourism reduces the inequalities across local populations and creating

sustainable communities to benefit both residents and tourists by, for example, promoting entrepreneurial businesses enabling residents to serve tourists. The resulting interaction between residents and tourists can strengthen cultural identities as well as create cross-cultural understanding. Furthermore, it is essential to have the goal of increasing educational opportunities for residents, enabling them to fully benefit from tourist activities. These goals, as well as the other goals relating to sustainability, require destinations to develop a new vision, one not solely measured by economic activity but also focuses on economic activity that benefits both residents and tourists while preserving the natural and cultural environment of the community. This can only be achieved when residents are involved in the branding or rebranding through a stakeholder process that includes residents.

The first step in creating a brand is to create the vision (Aaker, 2014). The vision sets the overall direction of the brand, giving the direction for creating the brand's identity. That identity should communicate how it creates value for the tourist and differentiate it from competitors (Aaker, 2008). The differentiation should both be unique and focus on attributes that create value for the tourists. Aaker (2008) states that at the heart of the brand's identity are 6–12 associations that represent the brand. These become brand values. For tourist destinations, these elements could include community, preservation of the environment, support for entrepreneurship, cultural exchange, hospitality and so forth. Additionally, the brand identity should include elements that are unique to the destination and create value for the tourists. These brand values should be embraced by residents and other stakeholders (e.g. DMOs, tourists, tourism companies, public authorities). In a corporate setting, brand identity elements must be embraced by the employees, as they must believe in the brand and what it stands for. This is particularly true in a service industry, such as hospitality or travel, where there is direct contact between employees and guests.

For a destination, residents not only casually encounter tourists but are also employees of tourist-related businesses. Thus, residents have a critical role in tourist satisfaction with their experience at the destination (Choo *et al.*, 2011). To maximize the value of the brand, residents must believe in the values and outcomes that are being communicated by the destination's identity. DMOs should make tourism decisions that reflect community interests and opinions (Byrd, 2007; Haywood, 2020). Furthermore, it is necessary to include residents in the representation of the brand – which, in turn, results in the destination achieving its goals (Choo *et al.*, 2011; Wassler *et al.*, 2021). For a DMO that has included goals based on UNWTO SDGs, the inclusion of residents in its branding is a requisite.

According to Carius and Job (2019), some of the main benefits of this approach are that decisions are based on available knowledge, democratically legitimated, and socially accepted. As pointed out by Haywood (2020), for tourism to become “smarter,” everyone's contextual realities and versions of “smarter” must be considered. For this, it is key to establish open communication channels with receptive governments (Choi and Sirakaya, 2005). Furthermore, all stakeholders need to work together toward socially responsible activities as perceived by residents (Gursoy *et al.*, 2019a). This is what Su *et al.* (2018) refer to as destination social responsibility.

A communication consultant suggests asking employees two questions: (1) Do you know what our brand stands for? and (2) Are these values important to you and are the ones you can believe in? (Kotler *et al.*, 2021). These questions should also be posed to residents of a tourist destination. If the destination follows UNWTO's strategic guidelines and focuses on sustainable goals that benefit both residents and tourists, then residents are likely to buy into the brand's identity elements, as well as benefit from tourism.

Conclusion

The rebranding of tourist destinations, following UNWTO's SDGs not only creates values that resonate with both tourists and locals but also provides a welcoming environment for tourists. This would eliminate the negative effects of residents feeling they do not benefit from tourism, leading to negative attitudes toward tourists and thereby creating an unwelcoming environment. Petty crimes perpetrated by residents against tourists can result in tourists barricading themselves from locals in all-inclusive resorts. On the other hand, when residents are involved with tourism stakeholders in the cocreation of their activities, this results in friendly cross-cultural exchanges (Vargo and Lusch, 2004, 2008). This cocreation of value can only occur if residents perceive they benefit from tourism and the tourists it brings. If residents feel a positive connection with tourists, the experience of tourists is greatly enhanced, the destination is perceived as an attractive place to visit and the long-term outlook for tourism is positive. Tourism that produces happy residents also produces happy guests and an environment that supports local culture, education and the preservation of the natural environment.

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